

He shrugged. “She’s gone,” he said. “Engaged to some guy in England.”

“Already?” I said, shocked.

He explained that less than a week after we had met her, she was introduced to a British movie mogul. After a few dates, she up and moved to London the minute the mogul committed.

My friend was distressed. He said, “I asked her, ‘What does this guy have that I don’t?’ She said, ‘A hundred million dollars.’ Then I said, ‘What’s he giving you that I didn’t?’ She said, ‘A bigger allowance.’”

I burst out laughing at his candor, and hers! At least she wasn’t trying to throw love into the equation. This was all about money for her, and getting more of it while she still could. Call her any name you want, but she wasn’t stupid.

This phenomenon is everywhere: from the Boston suburbs to the clubs of L.A. We live in a society that places a big premium on youth and beauty, and a lot of young people know this. I don’t mean to insult the millions of young people out there who’d never choose their date according to wallet size.

“Some gold diggers actually do have hearts of gold.” These are the words of Gerald Sadvari, one of the top divorce lawyers in the land. Part of his job is putting a tricky price tag on the value of a woman (or man) between the ages of twenty-four and thirty-eight, the average age of the so-called gold digger. He describes the classic gold-digger dynamic like this: old guy, young woman. The old guy’s marrying her only to bask in the corona of her youth and beauty, both of which are beginning to elude him. And she’s hoping to get pampered and spoiled while she’s young and pretty. Sex figures in, no doubt, but that’s none of my business. She probably suffers from the disease of “more.” Her rich compatriot, however, suffers from the disease of “not enough”—not enough glory, not enough recognition, not enough reassurance that he’s top dog in whatever field he works in. So he needs a symbol in the form of a human being to show the world—and other men—that he’s a winner. No matter what the dynamic, if there’s an ironclad prenup, the richer party will usually survive if it comes down to divorce. The gold digger will survive only if he or she has a good prenup, and only until the next sucker comes along.